Behind the Cart: Disclosure Score Methodology

Draft for expert review · November 3, 2026

Purpose and scope

Behind the Cart scores how much five technology companies disclose about the environmental footprint of their AI and data centers, using public reports read in November 2026. We ask experts to test the method before it is published.

- **Companies:** Google, Meta, Microsoft, Amazon, Apple.
- **What the score measures:** how much a company tells the public. It does not measure the size of its footprint or how well it performs. A company can be very open and still use a lot of electricity.
- **Why disclosure:** a study of about 1,000 companies by the AI Company Data Initiative found 97% did not publicly report assessing the environmental impact of their AI systems, as reported by Lab Manager. That study covers mostly companies that use AI, not only those that build it.
- **Where it lives:** the interactive version, with adjustable weights, is at super-future-visions.github.io/behind-the-cart.

The seven questions

Each company is scored on seven questions. Full marks means meeting the standard in the right-hand column, which is stricter than the grid on the page.

Question	Full marks would require
Total electricity use	Every year, in absolute units, for the whole company and for data centers, with the method and boundary stated
AI-specific electricity	Training and everyday use reported separately, with the method
Energy per AI prompt	Flagship models and more than text, with the method, the date, and independent review
Emissions by local grid	Location-based and market-based Scope 2 figures side by side
Water use	Consumption and withdrawal, totals and by site, with water stress noted and indirect water at power plants included
Numbers for each data center	Electricity and water per site, including leased and third-party hosted capacity
Independent checking	Third-party assurance on every disclosed metric, including the AI-specific ones

By this standard, no company in the sample earns full marks on the AI-specific questions today.

Scoring rules

Each answer earns 2 points if disclosed, 1 if partial, 0 if not found. Each question has a weight, and a company's score is its weighted points as a share of the maximum.

$$\text{score} = \Sigma\, w_i\, p_i \div (2\, \Sigma\, w_i)$$

Here p is the points for question i (0, 1 or 2) and w is its weight.

- **Default weights:** AI-specific electricity counts double, because the project is about AI. The other six questions count once. The maximum is 16 points.
- **Equal weights:** all seven count once, for a maximum of 14 points.
- **Reader control:** on the page, anyone can set each weight from 0 to 3 and see the scores update.
- **Levels:** 80% and above is Open, 60 to 79% Fairly open, 30 to 59% Patchy, below 30% Mostly dark.

Status definitions and sources

A cell is Disclosed only when we could read the data. The statuses are defined below.

Status	Points	Meaning
Disclosed	2	Answered with data we read, in the company's report or a reliable report of it
Partial	1	Answered in part: a narrow measure, ratios without totals, combined lines, or a stated exclusion
Not found	0	We looked in the sources we checked and did not find it. This is not proof it does not exist
Not checked	none	Excluded from scoring. No cell has this status now

Primary sources read directly: Meta's 2025 Environmental Data Index, Microsoft's 2026 Environmental Data Fact Sheet, Amazon's 2025 Scope 1 and 2 review schedule from Ernst & Young, and the summary page of Google's 2026 Environmental Report. We have not read Google's full report tables or Apple's appendix tables.

Cells that rest on secondary sources: Google electricity, emissions, site-level and assurance; Apple electricity, emissions and assurance; Amazon water; and Meta's model-card training figures. These come from news and analysis sites, and each needs checking against the company's own report.

Current results

Amazon scores lowest under both weightings, and Meta's lead disappears when all questions count equally.

Company	Default weights (of 16)	Equal weights (of 14)
Meta	10 points, 63%, Fairly open	9 points, 64%, Fairly open

Company	Default weights (of 16)	Equal weights (of 14)
Google	9 points, 56%, Patchy	9 points, 64%, Fairly open
Microsoft	9 points, 56%, Patchy	9 points, 64%, Fairly open
Apple	8 points, 50%, Patchy	8 points, 57%, Patchy
Amazon	5 points, 31%, Patchy	5 points, 36%, Patchy

The biggest gap for every company is AI-specific electricity. No company reports it. Amazon also loses points because we found no electricity total.

Judgment calls to review

Eight calls could change a company's score, and we are least sure about the first four.

1. **Google, energy per prompt: Partial.** Google published 0.24 Wh, 0.03 g CO_2e and 0.26 mL of water for the median Gemini text prompt in August 2025. It covers text only, one point in time (May 2025), excludes indirect water, and Google says it is not independently verified.
2. **Google and Microsoft, water: Disclosed.** Both report direct water only. The full-marks standard asks for indirect water at power plants, which Meta reports (72,207 ML embedded in purchased electricity in 2024). Under that standard both would be Partial.
3. **Microsoft, numbers for each data center: Disclosed.** We read its fiscal 2025 table as listing 29 locations. Bloomberg reports that among the largest cloud companies only Google and Meta publish site-level water, so the table may be regional or may leave out leased capacity. Needs a recheck.
4. **Meta and Apple, numbers for each data center: Partial.** Meta reports leased facilities as one combined line, about 17% of its 2024 electricity (3.07 of 18.42 TWh). Apple's colocation use was not revealed in 2024, per DataCenterDynamics.
5. **Amazon, water: Partial.** In June 2026 it disclosed a first total, 2.5 billion gallons for 2025. The figure excludes colocation sites and indirect water, and gives no site-level numbers.
6. **Independent checking: Partial for four, Disclosed for Apple.** Google, Meta, Microsoft and Amazon have limited assurance on part of their data. Apple's assurer gives reasonable assurance over selected figures. Whether the scope is comparable is unclear.
7. **Meta, AI-specific electricity: Partial.** Its Llama 3.1 model card reports training only, for one model family: 39.3 million GPU hours and 11,390 tonnes CO_2e location-based. No total or everyday-use figure was found.
8. **Double weight on AI-specific electricity.** This is an editorial choice. It decides whether Meta leads.

Known limitations

The score is a draft for expert review, and it has limits that a reader should know before relying on it.

- **Small sample.** Five companies. Cloud and AI providers outside this group are not covered.

- **Scale is ignored.** Apple's data centers are far smaller than Google's or Microsoft's, but the score treats them the same.
- **Boundaries differ.** Google and Meta report data-center electricity, Microsoft reports company-wide electricity, and Apple's figure covers its owned data centers only. Third-party cloud capacity a company rents is not counted for any of them.
- **Coarse scale.** Three levels per question hide differences within a level.
- **Snapshot in time.** Based on reports and coverage read in November 2026. Companies publish new data every year.
- **Absence is not proof.** “Not found” reflects the sources we checked, and some of those are secondary.
- **Editorial weights.** The default weighting reflects the project's focus on AI and is open to challenge.
- **No peer review yet.** This document is the first request for it.

Questions for reviewers

We most want your view on these six questions.

1. Are the seven questions the right ones? What is missing, for example hardware embodied carbon, backup generators and local air pollution, or grid strain?
2. Is a 2, 1, 0 scale with double weight on AI-specific electricity defensible? What would you use instead?
3. Should leased and colocation capacity, and indirect water, be required before a cell counts as Disclosed?
4. Which of the eight judgment calls above would you change, and why?
5. Do the level names (Open, Fairly open, Patchy, Mostly dark) describe the scores fairly?
6. Which primary sources did we miss, such as Google's full report tables, Apple's appendix, or Microsoft's site table?

How to respond: use the Challenge a number form. Companies are welcome to correct any cell. We will publish a corrections log.

Sources

Read directly:

- Meta, 2025 Environmental Data Index
- Microsoft, 2026 Environmental Data Fact Sheet
- Amazon, 2025 Scope 1 and 2 review schedule (Ernst & Young)
- Google, 2026 Environmental Report summary page
- DataCenterDynamics on Apple's 2024 data-center electricity
- Lab Manager on the AI Company Data Initiative study

Read through search excerpts or secondary coverage, to verify:

- Google on energy per prompt

- DataCenterDynamics on Amazon's 2.5 billion gallons
- The Planet Brief on Apple's 2026 report
- Latitude Media on Google's site-level water
- Policy Review on big tech's 2025 reports
- Datacenters on Map, Google and Meta electricity
- NVIDIA copy of the Llama 3.1 model card